

Turkey: US likely to keep Iranian gas offline

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【メール原文】

Washington will likely keep Iranian gas offline this winter as Turkey's Russian supply extension also lapses at year-end. Turkey's 25-year, 9.5 billion cubic meter (bcm) gas contract with Iran expired on 29 July, with only make-up shipments for previous shortfalls continuing. Russian contracts for 22 bcm, extended last year, also expire at year-end, leaving both supply lines in limbo amid a tight global market and potentially forcing Turkey to cover nearly half its gas imports through costlier alternatives. Gas accounts for nearly half of household energy use and a quarter of power generation, with imports supplying nearly all of Turkey's annual demand of almost 60 bcm.

Turkey

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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With Iranian gas halted since late summer and Russian contracts expiring at year-end, nearly half of Turkey's gas supply is in limbo amid a tight global market.

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We expect Russian gas to continue flowing but US pressure will likely keep Iranian flows halted, potentially adding up to 10% to Turkey's €60 billion energy import bill, with much of the cost falling on the public balance sheet.

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Washington's stance will test improving US-Turkey ties and could strengthen regional pushback against US pressure to curtail economic ties with Iran.

Washington will likely keep Iranian gas offline this winter as Turkey's Russian supply extension also lapses at year-end. Turkey's 25-year, 9.5 billion cubic meter (bcm) gas contract with Iran expired on 29 July, with only make-up shipments for previous shortfalls continuing. Russian contracts for 22 bcm, extended last year, also expire at year-end, leaving both supply lines in limbo amid a tight global market and potentially forcing Turkey to cover nearly half its gas imports through costlier alternatives. Gas accounts for nearly half of household energy use and a quarter of power generation, with imports supplying nearly all of Turkey's annual demand of almost 60 bcm.

Erdogan's UNGA visit failed to produce a breakthrough, and we expect Iranian gas to stay offline. The anticipated meeting with US President Donald Trump did not take place, and the Turkish delegation returned home without a solution. Our basecase is that Russian supply will continue, given Turkey's considerable dependence and Washington's past willingness to accommodate those flows—a contrast Ankara can't count on with Iran.

Turkey can absorb the loss of Iranian gas, but at a substantial cost. While contract prices are confidential, replacing Iranian gas at current spot prices could increase Turkey's €60 billion energy import bill by up to 10%. Residential gas is heavily subsidized, and paring back support is politically difficult. Energy subsidies cost \$15 billion last year alone, and Energy Minister Alparslan Bayraktar

signaled that tariff increases will track expected inflation rather than wholesale energy costs, leaving much of the additional cost on an already strained public balance sheet at a delicate point in Turkey's economic recovery. Washington nevertheless appears willing to have Ankara bear that cost rather than permit financial flows to Tehran.

Turkey cannot fully replace the volumes at risk. Plans to add 3.7 bcm annually from the Sakarya gas field by year-end would only partially close the gap. More Azerbaijani gas is an option, but production constraints and existing commitments may limit Baku's latitude. Ankara can also import more liquefied natural gas (LNG) through its floating storage and regasification units (FSRUs), or draw on nearly 6 bcm in storage. Turkey would still likely turn to spot LNG in an exceptionally tight winter market, with European benchmark Title Transfer Facility (TTF) prices around €80 per MWh, the highest since 2022 and more than double earlier this year. Spot LNG would widen the trade deficit, pressure reserves, and raise input costs.

The roadblock to restoring Iranian flows is political. Ankara had sought flexibility to preserve Iranian supply, but no solution has materialized. On 4 September, Bayraktar said Washington had yet to offer a formula to maintain the trade. Technical obstacles appear manageable: Finance Minister Mehmet Simsek has been stressing that a US-approved payment mechanism already exists, with funds restricted to permitted purchases. As well as blocking this specific arrangement, Washington appears set on closing off every revenue channel to Iran, however narrow. Already in March 2025, US pressure over Tehran's transit revenues ended Turkey's deal for 1.3 bcm of favorably priced Turkmen gas. If even this modest arrangement, involving Iran only as a transit country, proved unacceptable, Washington is unlikely to acquiesce to larger direct purchases of Iranian gas.

The fallout is likely to test the limits of improving US-Turkey ties. If Washington holds firm, and Turkey enters 2027 short of supply, it would test the recent rapprochement. Ankara's gains have lagged Saudi Arabia and the UAE. Although Trump sent positive signals at the NATO Summit, progress on Ankara's priorities, including sanctions under the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) and rejoining the F-35 program, has stalled. Washington is also uneasy with Ankara's ties to Moscow. Erdogan drew a rare rebuke from Trump after meeting Russian President Vladimir Putin and floating Turkish membership at this month's Shanghai Cooperation Organization's summit in Bishkek. Absent Iranian gas, Turkey would grow more reliant on Russia precisely as Washington seeks to curtail those ties, weakening Ankara's hand in negotiations with Russia over renewing supply beyond year-end. With Trump's room to maneuver narrowing after the midterms, any prolonged dispute that casts Turkey as far out of step on Russia or Iran would likely sap the bilateral thaw.

Washington's dilemma is that any accommodation for Ankara is hard to contain. Pressing Turkey too hard risks adding another irritant to an already complicated relationship, but an exception carved out for Ankara risks becoming a template for other countries. India has already sought a similar waiver for its Chabahar port operations, and Iraq, which depends heavily on Iranian gas and electricity, would have a case to make for the same treatment. Gulf states facing their own US pressure to curb trade and financial ties with Iran would take note of any flexibility shown to Ankara. That precedent risk, rather than the merits of any single case, is likely why Washington continues to resist even a workable mechanism.

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